

South Korea

Foreign Trade

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Actual	US\$8.7 bil
Previous [*]	US\$12.2 bil
Coverage	Jan. 2026
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[Definition](#) [Source](#)



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First Take

South Korea delivered a strong trade performance in January, with the surplus remaining high at \$8.7 billion despite easing from \$12.2 billion in December. Exports surged 33.9% year on year, supported by more working days versus a year earlier and solid semiconductor shipments. Imports rose 11.7%. We expect export growth to stay robust in early 2026 on the back of sustained semiconductor demand, although U.S. tariff risks and broader global trade frictions warrant close monitoring.

South Korea Foreign Trade, US\$ mil							
	Jan 26	Dec 25	Nov 25	Oct 25	Sep 25	Aug 25	Jul 25
Trade Balance	8,700	12,170	9,489	6,017	9,499	6,419	6,536
Exports	65,900	69,539	60,769	59,517	65,908	58,272	60,727
Imports	57,100	57,368	51,280	53,500	56,408	51,853	54,191
% change yr ago							
Exports	33.9	13.3	8.0	3.5	12.6	1.1	5.7
Imports	11.7	4.6	1.1	-1.5	8.3	-4.1	0.7

The Numbers

- South Korea posted a trade surplus of \$8.7 billion in January. Exports had their strongest ever January, thanks to more working days and robust semiconductor demand.
- Exports rose 33.9% y/y after rising 13.3% in December. Imports climbed 11.7% after rising 4.6% in the prior month.
- Across major export categories, a 102.7% year-on-year jump in semiconductors was noteworthy. Automobiles, another key export category, rose 21.7%. Machinery rose 8.6%, but petrochemicals dropped 1.5%.
- Exports to major trading partners rose, including to China (up 46.7%), the U.S. (up 29.5%), the EU27 (up 6.9%), and to ASEAN (up 40.7%).

Behind the Numbers

South Korea started 2026 on a solid footing, recording its 12th consecutive monthly trade surplus in January. That said, the headline strength should not be interpreted as a strong turnaround. January's strong export print was amplified by favourable calendar effects in a month that typically sees softer performances. This helped exports post their strongest January growth and extend their expansion to an eighth consecutive month.

Semiconductors were again the linchpin of the trade performance, with artificial intelligence-related demand buoying shipments of advanced chips. While automobiles and other manufactured goods also registered gains, momentum outside semiconductors was uneven. These sectors face a 15% U.S. tariff burden, which constrains competitiveness. We expect export growth to carry through the early months of 2026. Robust semiconductor demand will provide support amid limited gains in other segments.

Trade policy risks are elevated. The October U.S.–South Korea trade agreement lowering U.S. auto tariffs to 15% from 25% provides partial relief, but the burden remains substantial given South Korea's heavy reliance on U.S.-bound shipments. U.S. President Donald Trump last week threatened to raise tariffs back to 25%, underscoring political and policy uncertainty. The threat appeared to be more about pressuring Seoul to accelerate legislative approval of the 2025 trade agreement than signalling a breakdown in bilateral ties.

Exports to China and the U.S. declined in 2025. Favourable base effects flattered gains in other major markets. Although the trade surplus highlights South Korea's external resilience, rising protectionism and slowing global demand warrant caution. Semiconductor demand, the durability of trade agreements, and volatile global conditions will determine South Korea's trade trajectory in 2026.